

Since all the memory modules were in single-channel configuration, scores in the memory benchmarks were expectedly low—with the Acer Aspire SA80 scoring the lowest.

The DVD-RW drive on the Krypton was the fastest in this category, but the others weren't too bad.

In the gaming benchmarks—*Call of Duty* and *FarCry*—the Krypton Voyager 9, with the nVidia 6100, emerged the fastest, outperforming all the other graphics solutions and giving amazing frame rates. The Acer ASP V4324 with the GeForce4 MX 440 was second-best.

The Acer ASP V4324 and the Krypton were the fastest in our audio encoding test, and the Krypton was the fastest at video encoding. The Datamini Festiva MG Premium also exhibited top-notch performance in PCMark04, proving it had a well oiled sub-system. We therefore expected it to be the PC with the best overall performance. The Krypton scored 26.6 in Business Winstone 2004, which was the highest, and which means it's better suited than the others for office and business applications.

As we expected, the Creative 2.1 speakers, known for their better acoustics, produced great sound. But the 5.1 speakers accompanying the Datamini Festiva MG Premium sounded even better, and seemed to provide a more immersive experience.

Conclusion

The choice of better-quality components is one of the reasons for the markedly better performance (and somewhat higher prices) of the PCs in this segment, as compared to those in the Value segment.

The LG XD8 was the most expensive, being unreasonably priced at Rs 40,000. The Krypton Voyager 9 was the last PC we'd received for the test, and had we received it a few hours later, it might not have made it to the tests at all. Frankly, we'd expected an ordinary PC from Krypton, but we found a surprise package: this PC, powered by the Athlon64 3500+ and with 512 MB of RAM and a DVD-RW drive, was the best performing PC in this category. Had it been priced a bit lower, it would surely have won Gold.

BEST BUY
digit
JANUARY 2006



Acer ASP V4324

The Acer Aspire ASP V4324 at Rs 25,999 was the least expensive of the lot, while also being a good performer! Features, too, were top-notch; we therefore adjudge it, without reservation, the winner of the Digit Best Buy Gold in this category.

MEDIA CENTER PCS

You can do regular tasks on a Media Center PC (MCPC), but that's not what you'd be buying one for! A MCPC is meant to be the media hub of your living room, enabling you to listen to music, watch movies, pause live TV and replay it—and also get some work done! For all this, you'll need good horsepower, which, unfortunately, some MCPCs lack. But MCPCs have been in the market for quite some time now, and since we're comparing home PCs, we decided we had to include these in our comparison.

This segment was relatively unpopulated, with only four PCs qualifying as MCPCs. Remember that you'll only see branded PCs in the MCPC segment, since the components are chosen carefully to work in tandem with the OS. Assembling a PC to make it qualify as an MCPC would be impossible, because not all components conforming to the Windows XP Media Center Edition standard are available off-the-shelf—nor is the OS itself. This fact—that the hardware is so niche—also makes Media Center PCs much costlier than their home desktop counterparts.

We should mention here that the HCL PC, strictly speaking, didn't conform to the Windows XP Media Center Edition standard. It didn't come with a TV-Tuner at all. The Acer, too, didn't ship with one, but they did send it in as an "optional component."

Some of the old brands are here, and one new entrant in

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